The Stinky Princess

By Bruce Coville

INTRODUCTION

Have you ever felt like you just don't quite fit in? Have you ever been told you're too much of this or not enough of that? There isn't a single person on the planet that hasn't felt judged by others at some point in their lives.

Are we good enough, smart enough, pretty enough, skinny enough? Bruce Coville, in his children's story "The Stinky Princess," addresses the issues of being judged and self-acceptance.

But it's not just a children's story . . . there's a moral to his story teens and adults need to hear too!

ONCE THERE WAS a princess named Violet who didn't smell very good.

It had nothing to do with either her birth or her upbringing. In fact, she had started out smelling just fine. She smelled of clear mountain streams a moment before the rain comes, and of lilacs.

Violet found her own smell boring, and often

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declared that there must be many far more interesting scents in the world . . . .

[And then] Bindlepod the goblin came to visit. Bindlepod's skin was the color of rotting toadstools. His bare feet slapped on the stone floors of the castle like dirty dishrags. But the most distressing thing about him was his smell.

While nobody could say exactly *what* it was Bindlepod smelled of, everybody agreed that it was distinctly unpleasant. Everybody, that is, except the princess. She thought Bindlepod smelled quite interesting.

One day, the princess was walking in the castle garden when she spotted Bindlepod's frog. It was wearing its saddle, as if Bindlepod had just returned from a ride. A little farther on she spotted the goblin himself. He was perched on the stone wall, gnawing a raw fish.

Violet climbed onto the wall and took a seat next to Bindlepod. "What's it like in Goblinland?" she asked.

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Bindlepod shrugged. "Nice enough, if you're a goblin. We call it Nilbog, by the way, not Goblinland. That's rude. It would be like calling your kingdom Peopleland. "

"Is Nilbog smelly?"

Bindlepod closed his eyes and seemed to be remembering something. "Yes," he said at last, with just a hint of a smile. "Very."

"Let's go there," said the princess.

"You," said the goblin, "are walking trouble, a danger zone with feet."

"Does that mean no?" asked Violet.

"It means never in a million years!" Then he hopped down from the wall and whistled for his frog [for his trip home]. Late in the morning, Bindlepod's frog stopped in the middle of the road and said, "I am not taking another hop until you get that princess out of the saddlebag."

"What are you talking about?" cried Bindlepod in alarm.

"The princess," said the frog patiently. "She's

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in the saddlebag, and I'm getting tired of carrying her."

"Why didn't you say something before now?" asked Bindlepod, torn between exasperation and despair.

"She bribed me," said the frog. "With june bugs. You know I can't resist june bugs."

The shape of the saddlebag was distinctly suspicious. So Bindlepod unstrapped it from the frog, loosened the top, and turned it over. Out tumbled the princess.

Bindlepod sighed. "What are you doing here?"

"Going to Nilbog," said Princess Violet, picking herself up from the road and brushing the dust from her backside.

"You most certainly are not," said Bindlepod.

"Well, if it's not Nilbog, it will be somewhere else," she said. "I'm not going back, and you can't make me."

"She's got a point," put in the frog. "Even if you took her back, they probably wouldn't let her in

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on account of ... well, you know."

"I know," said Bindlepod. "The smell. You've been in my saddlebag for three hours already. Your parents may have put up with goblin smell on me, but they certainly aren't going to accept it on their daughter."

"Well, I'll just wash," said Princess Violet indignantly.

"Goblin smell doesn't come off with mere soap and water," said Bindlepod.

"What does it take?" asked the princess, indignation turning to alarm.

"A dip in Fire Lake, if I remember correctly," said the frog.

"Good grief!" cried Bindlepod. "We can't expect her to do *that!* There's no telling how she might come out. We're turning back. Even if the princess's parents don't let her in, we have to let them know what's happened. If we don't, they're going to assume I stole her, and before you know it we'll be at war."

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They had traveled only about a third of the way back to the castle when they found the king coming in their direction.

"Hail, King Vitril!" said Bindlepod. "I have your daughter," gesturing to where Violet was perched atop the frog. "I was just bringing her home."

Violet raced to her father's side. But when the king dismounted to embrace her, he made a terrible face. *"Euuuw!"* he cried. "You stink of goblin!" And, indeed, the princess-who had once smelled of apple blossoms and spiced muffins-now had a distinctly strange odor about her. The king looked at his daughter sadly. "I can't take you home like this. What do you think your mother would say if she got a whiff of you now? The smell would break her heart." He turned toward Bindlepod. "As she chose to go with you, I leave her to you." With that he bade his daughter farewell then climbed onto his horse and rode for home.

The astonished princess stood in the road, blinking back tears as she watched her father gallop

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away. It is, after all, one thing to run away from home. It is another thing entirely to run away and discover that they don't want you back. She sighed and turned her face toward Nilbog.

Narrow stone bridges took them across dark chasms. Winding passages with many tunnels branching to the sides carried them deeper into the earth. And at last they arrived at the entrance to Nilbog.

An enormously fat creature who looked something like a goblin, though not entirely, was leaning against one side of the entrance, cleaning his navel with a sharpened bone. When he saw them coming, he opened his yellow eyes a little wider but made no movement.

"Come here . . . Not you, Princess! Just Bindle-pod." Bending forward-not easy, given his enormous bulk-he began to sniff. *Sniff. Sniff sniff.* He frowned in disgust. "*Whooie!*" he cried. "You stink, Bindlepod! You smell of quiet rooms and cramped hearts, tiny minds and tiny places. You smell small and nasty."

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Hearing this, the princess grew nervous. "Does that mean he's not going to let us in?" she whispered to the frog in a quivering voice.

"If I sent you away, then I would have a tiny little mind, too, wouldn't I? You may enter. Just don't be surprised if people are not particularly happy to smell you."

Their reception at the court of the goblin king was no more encouraging than Violet's last interview with her father had been. The goblin king - a huge creature with leering eyes, fantastical warts in several colors, and a tongue as long as his arm - was sympathetic, but disturbed. "I am glad to have you back, Bindlepod," he said. "And your young lady friend is welcome to stay as well, of course. But really ... " With that, his voice trailed off, and his eyes rolled around, as if he was searching for exactly the right word.

The goblin queen, looked up and said, "Your father is troubled, son, on account of the princess's smell."

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"Son?" asked Violet in surprise. "You didn't tell me you were the *prince* of Nilbog!" Bindlepod shrugged. "And what's wrong with my smell, anyway?" continued Violet indignantly.

"You do smell of goblin," said the king wearily. "But you also smell of the world above. We will give you shelter, of course. But I fear my people will not be jolly in your presence."

Time proved the king to be correct. Though everyone in Nilbog was polite to Violet and Bindlepod, no one seemed terribly *comfortable* in the presence of either of them. The result was that Violet and Bindlepod spent more and more time alone together. Bindlepod and Violet fell in love.

"I can't say we were made for each other," said Bindlepod. "Even so," he continued, "I am glad we found each other."

"And why weren't we made for each other?" she asked, reaching up to pat his sallow cheek.

"Well, my stinky little sweetie, our smells are, to say the least, incompatible."

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As the weeks wore on, Violet began to realize that Bindlepod was right. Though they were utterly happy in each other's company, the other goblins were most uneasy with their relationship. She decided to seek help and learned the whereabouts of the wisest of goblins, an incredibly ugly female of astonishing age. Her name was Flegmire, and she lived in a cave at the edge of Nilbog.

Standing at the front of the cave, Violet called, "May I enter, o Wisest of the Wise?"

"Yeah, yeah, come on in," replied a gravelly voice. Flegmire sat on the floor playing with a collection of colored rocks. The ancient gobliness held up her hands, cried, "Wait! Wait!" and then farted with such violence that it raised her several inches off the floor.

The smell caused Violet to gasp in shock. Flegmire, however, sighed in contentment and said, "Well, now that I can think again, tell me what it is you want."

Eyes watering, the princess explained her

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difficulty.

Flegmire hooked a curved green fingernail over her enormous lower lip. "You can't think of anything yourself? No hints you've had along the way?"

She swallowed nervously. "Well, Bindlepod's frog did mention something about ... Fire Lake."

Flegmire spread her arms as if the whole thing had been the essence of simplicity. "Well, there you go! If you already knew about that, why did you come here to bother me?"

That night Violet put on her riding clothes, then slipped out the door, intending to saddle up the frog and ride to Fire Lake. But she hadn't gone more than ten paces from her door when Bindlepod stepped from behind an enormous mushroom and said, "Going somewhere, my darling?"

Violet jumped and gasped. "What are you doing here?" she cried.

If you are going to do this thing, then so am I," said Bindlepod. "There's no point in only one of us taking the risk. If we're going to change, we might as

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well change together."

In a few hours they were standing at the edge of Fire Lake. The blazing waves hissed and crackled as they rolled against the shore. Bindlepod took Violet in his arms. He held her close, burying his nose in her neck.

"You know," he murmured, "I like the way you smell."

"And I like the way you smell," she replied.

"Then what are you going to do this for?" cried the frog. "Are you out of your minds? What do you care what the others think? It's none of their business! You love each other the way you are. Who are you going to change for?"

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Princess Violet and Prince Bindlepod never did step into Fire Lake. What they did do was build a home for themselves in a giant oak tree halfway between the gates of her father's kingdom and the entrance to Nilbog. Part of the home was in the branches, and part beneath the roots. It smelled of

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sky and leaves, of stone and soil, and they loved it nearly as much as they loved each other.

Though they never went back to either kingdom, their home was always open to anyone who cared to visit, and who would take them as they were.

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